Mughals, Macnaghten was reported by Emily to be ‘half mad . . . actually dancing about the deck with rage’ at the breach of protocol.[67] ‘Mr Torrens and Mr Macnaghten nearly fainted away on their deck because George ventured ashore after a bit of impromptu amusement,’ agreed Fanny. The following day in Ghazipur the Edens ‘gave another shock to Mr Macnaghten’s constitution by going ashore without a single aide-de-camp or any other badge of a Governor General about George. When we get to camp we mean to reform and behave better, though as it is, it seems to me that we are always going to be sailing about in a cloud of peacock’s feathers, silver sticks and golden umbrellas.’[68] Emily conceded that Macnaghten, for all his pomposity, had a reputation as a clever aide, and refers to him as ‘*our* Lord Palmerston, a dry sensible man, who wears an enormous pair of blue spectacles . . . he speaks Persian rather more fluently than English; Arabic better than Persian; but for familiar conversation rather prefers Sanscrit’.[69]

Mrs Macnaghten meanwhile was busy trying to stop her Persian cat eating her parakeet – one ayah was employed solely to guard and feed the bird – while worrying about being robbed by footpads creeping aboard the boat during the night: ‘the previous year they broke into Mrs Macnaghten’s tent and stole all her clothes so that Macnaghten had to sew her up in a blanket and drive her to Benares for fresh things’.[70]

Fanny found the Macnaghtens especially insufferable during the formal durbars that were held intermittently along the banks of the Ganges:

> The only amusing part of this business is the extreme gravity and emphasis with which Macnaghten translates every word that passes, never moving a muscle of his very unmovable countenance. ‘He says, my Lord, that your Lordship is his father and mother, his uncle and aunt, that you make his night and day, that he has no pillar to lean upon but you.’ All the attar of rose ceremonies he conducts with the same solemnity. I never saw a man more born for this business.

Later, during a visit to an elderly rani, ‘Macnaghten, in the most solemn manner, returned this answer: “The Rani, my Lord, says it is utterly impossible for her to express how inconceivably well she feels that your Lordship has entered her dwelling . . . she was feeling as a locust in the presence of an elephant . . .” Mrs Macnaghten, who does not in fact understand the language much, acts as interpreter [for Fanny and me]. O my dear, such a woman, she will be the death of me.’[71]